CHAPTER 39

JOHNSON'S REVENGE

21 November 2013–7 January 2014

AUSTRALIA vs ENGLAND, five Test matches

Australia won the series 5-0

M Johnson: 37 wickets for 517 runs *(average 13.97; best figures 7–40)*

I have seen it happen to other teams from the outside. The shifting sands and natural laws of the universe parting a once fully functioning group of cricketers, breaking them up and sending them back into the world, each with their own list of how they have been mistreated and where it went wrong. There's a cyclical nature to it – teams being created, brimming with productive tension, then falling apart. I've been part of the restructuring, coming in for bowlers who themselves did not want to go. From the inside though, it is harder to detect. This team is one that feels like mine, feels like *ours*, and when something is yours, a person can find it less conceivable that the same fate will happen to them. Since Strauss and Flower picked it up in the West Indies and got to grips with us, shaping and moulding each of us, the pack brimming with a sense of familiarity over time, a habit of focus and culture for winning becoming part of us, we have achieved so much. We have done it in such a short space of time too; a unit inside which I have thrived and felt a profound sense of purpose as the leader of the pack.

The dents in this team have begun to show themselves, at first in tiny moments of body language or dissent, of ten-minute spells of unusual haphazardness in the field, and increased segregating of different groups of friends within the dressing room. The KP situation involving South Africa